

Angola

 In 1975, after a long war, Angola became independent of Portuguese colonial rule. With fertile land and huge reserves of diamonds, oil, and natural gas, the country should have become prosperous. However, Angola was torn apart and economic development was restricted by the fighting that continued after independence. Civil war erupted between rival ethnic groups and continues today.



Oil and diamonds

Most of Angola's oil is produced in Cabinda, a tiny Angolan enclave in Dem. Rep. Congo. Petroleum provides 90 per cent of Angola's exports. Angola also ranks highly in world output of diamonds, its second largest export.

ANGOLA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Luanda
AREA	1,246,700 sq km (481,351 sq miles)
POPULATION	12,900,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Portuguese
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, traditional beliefs
CURRENCY	Readjusted kwanza



Luanda

Founded by the Portuguese in 1575, Angola's capital and largest city is home to more than 2,500,000 people. Once used for shipping slaves to Brazil, it is still a major seaport. Modern Luanda is an industrial centre with its own oil refinery.

Zambia

 Bordered to the south by the Zambezi River, Zambia is a country of upland plateaus, 80 per cent of which are grassland and forest. About 50 per cent of the people live by subsistence farming, constantly threatened by drought. Tobacco is the main exported crop. Hydroelectric power provides much of Zambia's energy. Low copper prices in the 1980s upset finances.



ZAMBIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Lusaka
AREA	740,720 sq km (285,992 sq miles)
POPULATION	9,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	English, Bemba, Tonga, Nyanja, Lozi, Lunda
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, traditional beliefs
CURRENCY	Zambian kwacha

Cobalt is used in steel production.



Copper forms 90 per cent of exports.

Copper bracelets

Copper and cobalt

Zambia is the world's sixth largest producer of copper. The seam of copper ore where the metal is mined, the Copperbelt, is 320 km (200 miles) long. The second largest producer of cobalt, Zambia also mines lead, silver, and zinc.

Urban living

About half of Zambia's people, a mix of more than 70 different ethnic groups, live in towns and cities. The most populated area is the Copperbelt, where most of them work. The capital, Lusaka, a thriving industrial and business centre, is home to 1,800,000 Zambians.

Namibia

 An ex-German colony, and ruled for 70 years by South Africa, Namibia won its independence in 1990. Rich mineral resources make mining the country's leading industry. One in seven people lives on the land, mainly rearing livestock, although drought and the expanding desert make farming difficult. Fishing is good off the Atlantic coast.

Himba woman



NAMIBIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Windhoek
AREA	823,290 sq km (317,260 sq miles)
POPULATION	1,739,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	English, Afrikaans, Ovambo, Kavango
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Namibian dollar



Uranium

The Rössing Uranium Mine in the Namib Desert is the world's largest, producing 2,000 tonnes (2,200 tons) of uranium every year. Namibia is the world's fifth largest producer of uranium and ranks among the top producers of diamonds.

People

Namibia has a peaceful multiracial society. The white minority lives mostly in Windhoek, in European-style houses. Black Namibians include many groups, the largest of which are the northern Ovambo. To the west, the semi-nomadic Himba raise cattle.

Hair is braided and beaded.

Botswana

 Southwest Botswana is covered by the Kalahari Desert. To the north is the marshy delta of the Okavango River, a haven for wildlife. Despite this wetland, however, Botswana suffers droughts. Most people live in the more fertile east. Production of diamonds – the third largest in the world – has helped to stimulate Botswana's economy.

Beef stew with dried spinach

Savoury porridge



BOTSWANA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Gaborone
AREA	566,730 sq km (218,814 sq miles)
POPULATION	1,600,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	English, Tswana, Shona, Khoikhoi, Ndebele
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Traditional beliefs, Christian
CURRENCY	Pula



San

The original inhabitants of Botswana are the nomadic San people, once known as Kalahari Bushmen, one of Africa's only remaining groups of hunter-gatherers. There are fewer than 50,000 San today, but small groups still roam the Kalahari Desert hunting small animals and eating edible plants and insects. Many San now work on cattle ranches.

Food

The Tswana people, who make up the majority of Botswana's population, live mostly by subsistence farming, raising cattle, and growing enough maize, sorghum, and millet for their own use. Their staple diet consists of meat stews served with a kind of porridge made from cereals. Fresh vegetables are rare.